D. G. Doubleday
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D. G. Doubleday
918 Adeline Street
Oakland
May 12, 1906
Dear Sir:

The earthquake occurred at San Francisco April 18th, at 5:12, and lasted just twenty-eight seconds. Of the 450,000 people comprising the population, at least 435,000 were in bed at the time. The first sensations were those of curiosity as to what had caused a person to wake up at that unusual hour; this, however, was soon satisfied, for the rocking of the beds made a person fully conscious that he was being shaken by subterreanan [sic] forces. My own personal experiences were those of hundreds of thousands; we all had the same sensations in regard to the earthquake effects. When you read the following account of my own personal experience, you read that of the entire population.

Immediately on being awakened I arose with the sole thought of getting on my feet. The other members of my family were doing the same thing, and I think we all jumped at the same instant. There were six persons in my residence—my wife, a little girl two years of age, my brother, a visitor and one servant. We were all soon huddled together in the drawing-room, when the severest shock came, and it seemed as though the end of the world had come—that we were being shaken into eternity. We could hear the terrible roar caused by a combination of falling bricks, walls, boards, etc., all over the city and the escaping gas coming from the earth. The house jumped back and forth with such seeming viciousness that the seconds during the quake seemed an eternity. One of my family cried out, "My God, will it ever stop?" That same expression was certainly cried by nine-tenths of the people in San Francisco some time during that twenty-eight seconds, and in the same words. With one vicious shake it eased down to a gentle rocking and then subsided with slight undulations. The sensations of that short time cannot be pictured by words. It was an experience that I now look back to, and I would not trade it for all the wealth of the world. There is nothing a man can feel see or hear that will so impress the mind with the power of Nature as did that earthquake. This thought rose at once to my mind—how helpless we are against the enormous force that could shake and jump, no one knows how many millions of tons of rock and earth, backward and forward with such rapid vibrations. Observers on the outside who witnessed its manifestations in the streets, told me that the telephone poles, trees, houses and business blocks rose and fell like the waves of the sea in a storm, that the trees and poles went back and forth until they touched the earth. They had the same thought as expressed above—that the end of the world had come. Several who witnessed it from out of doors told me that their wills at once acted upon their own volition and seemed to set

entirely upon the thought of going through the change from this world to the next with complete consciousness of the change taking place. All earthly things were forgotten—no one thought of money, house or bonds in that terrible twenty-eight seconds. No one tried to save anything—it was simply to get into the open air. Everybody in San Francisco arose from bed that morning and were in the streets within a period of time ranging from ten to forty seconds, depending upon the distance they had to go, and the number of stairs they had to descend to get there. My residence was on Clay street, on one of the beautiful hills of San Francisco, commanding a splendid view of the entire business section. Upon reaching the street I listened and talked for a few minutes with neighbors,

who were, like myself, in bed-time clothes. I could hear the distant roar, something entirely different from the ordinary sounds of the business section at that time in the morning. I tried to look over the city, but could see nothing, as the air was filled with an immense cloud of dust and dirt arising from the shaken walls and demolished structures. The thought came to me in these words, "Something terrible has happened down town." My house and those about me all stood the shock with comparatively little damage. However, I immediately rushed into the house, dressed myself, took my large touring automobile from the barn and started down town just as fast as I could make it go—seventy miles and hour. I met other machines rushing down town loaded with business men, all intent on getting into the business section and seeing the effect of the shake. I went down Clay street eight blocks, turned to the right down Fillmore for about twelve blocks, then to the left down Golden Gate avenue, which leads straight to the center of the business section. Understand, that within five minutes after getting out of my house I was three miles from home, tearing down Golden Gate avenue as fast as my car could go. When about half a mile from Market street on Golden Gate avenue, I could see the reflection of fires starting south of Market street, and in so many places that it frightened me for the safety of the city. As I turned a corner down Larkin street I came upon a fire engine and saw a whole block of buildings in flames right before me. Then I said to myself, "San Francisco is doomed," for I had just caught another glimpse of a dozen fires all blazing toward the sky, and scattered all over the southern section of the city.

I rushed over piles of brick with the machine at full speed. How I ever got over them I do not realize now, for it would be the last thing in the world I would attempt—to climb some of those same piles of brick with an automobile. I went down Market. The City Hall was a heap of ruins, covered with its own white and ashen dust. The thought of Pompeii and Herculaneum came to my mind, and it seemed as though San Francisco was a thousand years old, with its ruins of centuries stretched before me. However, as I proceeded, this impression changed as I saw on one hand and the other some tall, immense building of recent structure standing solid, intact, without a perceptible crack or a brick misplaced. San Francisco's new modern buildings, many of them costing millions of dollars, stood the test, while the weaker, older structures were crumbled or split here and there. The Call building, the tallest piece of architecture west of Chicago, stood like a sentinel watching the flames gathering headway south of Market. I rushed past the Call building down Montgomery street about a half mile to Pine street, the financial mart of the Pacific Coast. As I turned the corner I saw the Anglo-Caliornian [sic] Bank on Sansome street, one block from my offices, in flames and past saving. For three blocks behind it was a solid mass of flames. The San Francisco National was opposite the Anglo-Californian, and the fire was eating its way directly to it from the rear. The fire department was helpless with so many fires at once all over the city. There was no chance to save the business section, to my mind, and I at once entered my offices.

The Stock Exchange building was solid granite, a beautiful structure, the finest mining stock exchange building in the world. My offices took in the entire front, both sides of the entrance with doors opening from the general broad passageway to either side. Around on the sides in front were distributed the ten largest single plate glass windows west of Chicago. These windows were imported from Europe, and were of the finest prismatic glass, clear almost as a diamond. I noted these windows at once to see how they stood the shaking. Not a single one was cracked. They were hung on cushions in the casings, and stood that terrific shaking when

every other window, half their size, in San Francisco was shattered to chips. Those windows standing unhurt was one of the wonders of the city. The building itself was not damaged, but stood there still without a stone misplaced, one of the most solid structures in the world. I looked at the Western Union clock in my office—it had stopped at 5:12. It was now 5:30. You can see how fast men moved that morning.

I began work gathering valuable securities from my vaults, safes, desks, cabinets, and, indeed, everywhere I knew them to be. I took many large baskets which I used for mailing and dumped the contents of stock boxes, check-books, contracts, by the basketful, into them. I opened letter cabinets and dumped filed letters, due tags, ledgers, cash books, trust books, indeed, all and everything valuable into these large wire baskets. I was the first banker or broker on the street to enter his own offices. It was now past 6 o'clock, and other brokers were congregated on the corners watching the fire or endeavoring to reach their offices. Some even came into my offices while I was tearing things up and remarked that I was "panicky." Time was too precious to exchange views on such a subject, at least I thought so.

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My sole thought was upon the hundreds of thousands of dollars represented in my books and securities, the loss of which would reach over five thousand people all over the world. I knew from personal correspondence with clients that many of them had too much at stake on my records and in my vaults to take chances in such a case. I loaded the machine full of ledgers, books, stocks, etc., and rushed to my residence through crowds of people rushing down town. How I ever got through without running down a dozen persons is something I cannot explain. Then back again I came to the office at highest speed, with my brother following with my other automobile. We loaded up again. I worked to get only those things which could not be replaced the valuable securities, books and records. Cabinets, desks, even ore specimens can be replaced, but the written records and accounts of the enormous diversified business I was doing were beyond value for the reason that they carried the interests of others.

It was now half past six and the other business men of the section were tearing about wild to get horses or wagons, offering all kinds of prices for them, too. My clerks were now on hand, having rushed down as fast as possible, and together we went through the desks, cabinets, safes, etc., and made a last clean sweep of everything, so that we would lose nothing carrying records. I had a whole dray load of books, and you can imagine what a load we carried back and forth from the office. After the offices were cleared I went to a safe deposit box in one of the banks and took out a few diamonds which were left me by my father. These I stuck in my pocket with some small bills of money. When I reached the house the bills were dropping through my trousers, and I at once began looking for the diamonds. They were gone. I took the machine again and went back to Pine street in the hopes of finding them in the office where possibly they might have dropped. I found them in the street where I had started the auto. They represented a money value of several thousand dollars.

My books were now safe. The automobiles were worth their weight in gold by this time. I at once began helping some broker friends save their books and papers, and soon had another big load, representing several hundred thousand dollars of valuable securities, which I took to my house and kept guarded by rifles. For those four days I had over two million dollars worth of marketable securities in my house, protected by three friends who stood over them night and day with loaded guns. To my automobiles several brokers owe their ability to pay their accounts in full.

To go back. At 6 o'clock the regular soldiers from the Presidio had been distributed to every bank, safe deposit vault, the mint, postoffice [sic], indeed, every place in the city where immense value was stored. Fast work, indeed! Men of business rushed like mad through the city, while the streets were being crowded with the tourists out to gaze upon the enormous conflagration now spreading all through the business section.

Corps of dynamiters went rushing break-neck speed through the streets driving people out by squads of soldiers with fixed bayonets; then dynamiting whole blocks to stop the spreading flames. Immense stone and

iron structures were leveled to the ground in one second. The roar was getting terrible, and at every explosion the whole city shook from end to end. Looters were shot down on the instant of detection. Order ruled by instructions to shoot given to every company. There was no argument with the soldiery. It was obey or be shot. Automobiles, wherever seen, were taken by the soldiers at the point of the bayonet. The driver was given orders with a soldier beside him. It was drive as instructed or be killed. I drove my machine home after saving all I could and then proceeded to help others who were helpless. I received a written order from General Funston so that I could drive my autos anywhere because they were thus in the public service, working for the public's good. For two whole days and nights I and some friends carried sick people from houses ahead of approaching flames. Wealthy people would offer me thousands of dollars to carry them to the park or places of safety. It was life we were saving then. Our work was with the sick and helpless who would be left to perish. This kind of work continued until the Friday night following the 18th, when the fire was checked. It was a terrible strain, but human nature rises to great heights on such occasions.

All persons were doing what I have described, to the best of their individual abilities. Every saloon in the city was closed by soldiers thirty-five minutes after the fire started, and guarded with bayonets. All the wildest and roughest element was loosened, but the instructions to the soldiers under the martial-law proclamation were so severe that the rough

element, cut-throats, robbers—always to be found in a large city—were held in awe. Many of them were shot down as they attempted to rob others. From this standpoint the city was controlled absolutely, and all praise be given those in authority for it, too.

The fire swept an area of 450 square blocks; three times the area of the Chicago fire. San Francisco always did things on a big scale; she has given to the world the greatest fire and the greatest mass of ruins in all history. Had the earthquake taken place any time up to 12 o'clock midnight, or any time during the day, there would have been [250,000?] people burned to death. It might have been worse.

Over $450,000,000 worth of property was destroyed. One thousand lives were lost.

The banks and financial interests back of San Francisco are the richest in the world. They will come through this calamity and build up the city again, greater, grander and more beautiful than ever. The fear of earthquakes has now gone by. We will never have another, and now stand in no more danger from them than does New York or Chicago.

The San Francisco Stock Exchange brokers had larger credit with banks; a larger clientage of traders and customers; better financial standing, than other mining exchange brokers in the world. They have done the largest mining stock business in history, and the experience behind this business will shortly show the world the spirit of financial San Francisco. The San Francisco Stock and Exchange Board has done more business in one day in the Nevada stocks, now active, than has been done in a month by all the outside brokers together. The Exchange will do business at the old [illegible line of text] not be downed. They will all meet every obligation dollar for dollar. Within the next two years you will see them back again in a larger, grander exchange building. By the first of next month you will see them with headquarters doing business as usual. There is only one outcome for the courage and spirit being manifested by San Francisco business men of all classes—under such a calamity—a world-beating record for getting back into business again. Stay with the business men of San Francisco, for they are worthy of your best patronage.

I have almost closed every account on my books—dollar for dollar. I am ready for business, and will give clients the same honest straightforward service I did before. I start with a new set of ledgers — market letters as usual. Buy the good Johnnie stocks like you did the good Bullfrog stocks, the good Goldfield and Tonopah stocks.

I thank you for past favors and assure you that the kind letters of sympathy I have received have shown me that underlying the American instinct for business is a very deep feeling of common brotherhood and humanity. The kind letters I have received make me feel as though I knew all my clients personally, and that they are my personal friends. I have arranged for new vaults, new offices; the banks advise me that my credit is better than ever; that I can get all the money I ask for. I intend to build up my business at once and double it before one year passes. All business men feel the same and they will make good. The personal honor and integrity of our business men is an asset now drawing abundant capital from all over the earth.

Do not let any cut-rate brokers take advantage of you—the Nevada market holds good, and solid—wait until the Exchange opens and you see the real prices again.

My temporary address until 'Frisco offices are fitted is 918 Adeline street, Oakland, Cal.

Yours very truly
D. G. Doubleday.